

Open-Source Project Hack-a-thon

Build on a real project, with a real team, for the fun of it.

Foreword

This started as a simple idea: to find and work on an open-source project for course work credit. When the idea was presented to the class in Spring 2026, they decided they wanted to start our own CIS open-source project that would cross courses and semesters to be a living legacy of what CIS students could accomplish as a team. They chose an open-source video game, and began putting the first pieces of it in place, and said, “how about we have a hack-a-thon to build it.” This semester we extend the project with another hack-a-thon.

This document exists to give that effort a little structure so it can keep going and so everyone can take part. That is all it is. It is not meant to turn a good thing into paperwork.

The spirit of the whole thing is simple: it is a real project, it is yours, and the point is to build, cooperate, and enjoy being part of something larger than a single assignment. You are not graded on how impressive the result appears. You are asked to show up, take part in good faith, and contribute to the effort. If you do that, you have met it.

Cyberdemons Roguelike: <https://discord.gg/QADwedtr2E>

1. What This Is

The project is an open-source video game that students started last semester and are continuing to build. It is genuinely ongoing, which means your work can become part of something that outlives this course. Two of your fellow students serve as project managers and help coordinate the effort day to day (see the list in Course Information). A broader group of senior developers sets the technical foundation early in the semester, described in Task W03 below.

There are two graded parts to the Hack-a-thon, and only two:

- **Task W03: Setting the Foundation:** The senior developers set direction for the project, and the whole team meets to align on it. Runs from Week 3 through Week 6.
- **Task W13: The Hack-a-thon:** The event itself, held the weekend of November 9, where the team works together to move the project forward.

Everything else in this document supports those two tasks or offers you an optional way to get more involved. Take the parts that interest you.

2. Task W03: Setting the Foundation

Points: 20. Runs from Week 3 through Week 6. What you need to do depends on whether you are one of the project's senior developers or joining as a junior developer this semester.

This task has two tracks. Read the one that applies to you. Both tracks come together at one meeting by the end of Week 6.

If you are a senior developer

You are in this track (see the list in Course Information)

- **Discord Introduction:** Post a short introduction in the introductions channel, including any experience you have with building your own video game. Do not undersell this. Experience matters and we want to know about it.
- **Meet by the end of Week 3:** Meet with the other senior developers to set the project's direction before the junior developers arrive. The two project managers lead this meeting.
- **Produce the foundation artifact by the end of Week 4:** A short written document covering the project's scope, the architecture and coding conventions you have agreed on, and an initial breakdown of what needs doing. This is what the rest of the team will build from.
- **Set the Hack-a-thon date and time:** Decide the exact schedule for the November 9 weekend (see Task W13) and include it in the artifact. The available window runs from Friday at noon through Sunday evening; you do not have to use all of it.
- **Attend the Week 6 group meeting:** Present the artifact to the whole team and take part in the discussion.

If you are a junior developer

You are in this track (see the list in Course Information)

- **Join the Discord server and introduce yourself:** Post a short introduction in the introductions channel, including any experience you have with building your own video game. Do not undersell this. Experience matters and we want to know about it.
- **Read the foundation artifact:** The senior developers will share it by the end of Week 4. Read it before the Week 6 meeting so you arrive with a sense of where the project stands.
- **Attend the Week 6 group meeting:** This is where you meet the senior developers, hear about the project, and find your place in it.

The Week 6 group meeting

Everyone comes together for one meeting by the end of Week 6. The two project managers lead it. It is not meant to be formal, but it does need enough structure that it is clear who is running it, that a real discussion happens, and that everyone leaves with a solid understanding of where the project stands. Senior developers present the foundation artifact and are welcome to raise anything else worth discussing. If you are a junior developer, do not worry about how you will contribute yet. Everyone will find a way to help before this project is done.

If you cannot attend a meeting

This applies to both the senior developers' Week 3 meeting and the Week 6 group meeting. If you have a genuine conflict, talk to me before the meeting, not after. I will work with you and the senior developers to find a way for you to catch up on what you missed. Handling a conflict this way, ahead of time, with your manager and your team, is part of the professionalism this project is meant to build.

3. Getting Involved During the Semester (Optional)

Between Task W03 and the event, you are welcome to work on the project, talk about it in Discord, and contribute as much or as little as you like. None of this is required. It is here because the project is real and some of you will want to be part of it before November. If that is you, jump in. The foundation artifact from Task W03 includes a breakdown of what needs doing, which is a good place to look if you are not sure where to start.

The Contribution Bonus

Real contribution to the project is worth recognizing on its own. If you contribute to the project outside of the Hack-a-thon weekend itself, meaning during the regular semester, you can earn bonus points added directly to your Task W13 score. This does not replace any other assignment. Every other Task and Lab is still fully required, for everyone.

- **Up to 20 bonus points:** Added to your Task W13 score for real, verified contributions made outside the hackathon weekend. Twenty points is the cap for the semester, not per contribution.
- **The contribution has to be real and visible:** It must be actual work that lives in the project, a change that is now part of the game, a problem solved, a feature added, not a description of work you intend to do. If it is not in the project, it does not count.
- **The managers assess it:** The two project managers review what you contributed and recommend a point value based on its significance. I make the final decision on how many points, if any, get added.
- **The window runs through the end of Week 15:** Contributions can be brought forward any time during the semester, up through the end of Week 15.

A note on Week 15 and the holiday. Week 15 is Thanksgiving week. Nothing about this project is expected or required over the holiday. The window simply remains open through that week as a courtesy for anyone who, on their own, wants to keep working. Please treat the break as your break.

How a contribution gets verified

The two project managers review the contributions. They are peer-reviewing your work: they confirm that it is genuinely yours, that it is real, and they recommend a bonus point value based on its significance to the project. I make the final decision. The managers witness and advise; the grade decision is mine.

You record a contribution using the Contribution Bonus Record (a short, separate form). One record per contribution.

4. Task W13: The Hack-a-thon

Points: 80, plus up to 20 bonus points. The weekend of November 9. The bonus points come from contributions made outside the hackathon weekend, described above.

This is the main event, and the idea behind it is deliberately simple: work as a team to move the project forward, and enjoy it. There are no strict requirements, no deliverables to hit, and no report to agonize over. Discuss, build, learn, and cooperate without worrying about whether you are “doing enough.”

You do not need to be present for every hour of the weekend. You are expected to be part of the live effort: there for the discussions, contributing to the work, present with your team, whether in the lab or on Discord. As long as the team and I can see that you took part in good faith, you have met it.

How the points are earned

Take part in good faith and you have met it. If you show up, work with your team, and contribute to the effort, you have earned the points. This is not scored on how much you produce or how polished it is.

After the event you will fill out a short form (the Hack-a-thon Contribution Form) noting what you worked on and who you worked with. It takes a few minutes and is not graded on length or writing. Its only job is to record that you took part, so the points are documented. The real evidence is your participation, which the managers and I see directly during the event.

If you cannot attend

If you have a genuine conflict with the November 9 weekend, talk to me first, before the event, and we will find a reasonable way for you to take part. The door is open; walking through it just means having the conversation early.

This is meant to be fun and it is meant to be real. Take it in that spirit, take part in good faith, and it will be one of the great things you do this term.

5. Quick Reference

Table 1. *Hack-a-thon at a glance*

Item	Detail
Task W03, senior developers	Meet by end of Week 3. Foundation artifact and hackathon schedule by end of Week 4. Attend the Week 6 group meeting. 20 points.
Task W03, junior developers	Join Discord and introduce yourself. Read the foundation artifact. Attend the Week 6 group meeting. 20 points.
Task W13: Event	Weekend of November 9, in the lab and on Discord. 80 points.
Discord	Join, introduce yourself, set your nickname to your real name.
Contribution bonus	Optional. Earn up to 20 bonus points on Task W13 for real, manager-verified contributions made outside the hackathon weekend. Window runs through end of Week 15.
Attendance issue	Talk to me before either meeting and we will work it out.
The form	Short, ungraded, a record that you took part.